

Order Passeriformes continued

Family Pellorneidae

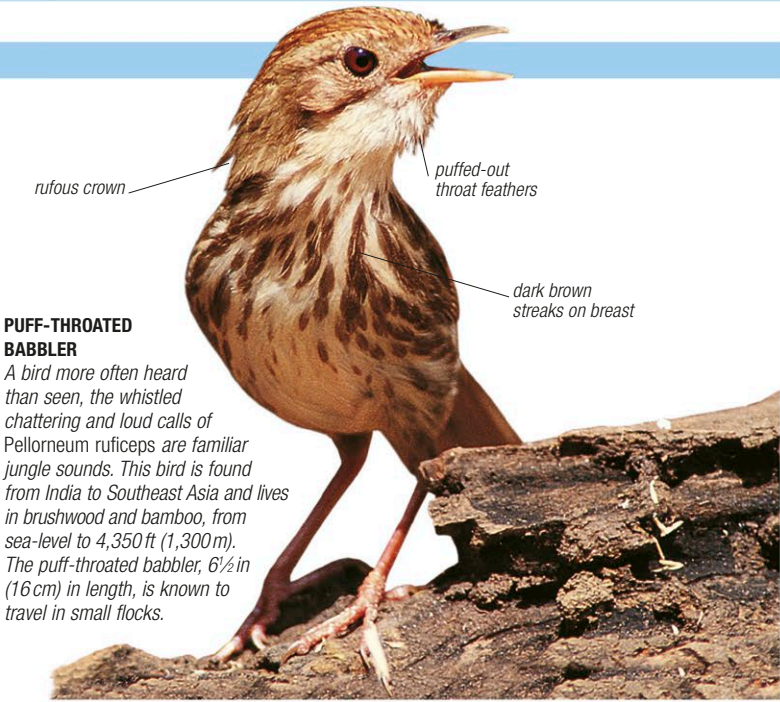
Fulvettas and ground babblers

Length 3¼–4¼ in (8–11 cm)
Species 70



This family links babblers and Old World warblers, but the fulvettas look rather like tits, with their round heads, large eyes, and stubby bills. Their pale eyes give them an unusual expression among small birds, and plumages are varied, with distinct head stripes or cheek patches. The golden-breasted fulvetta is a particularly bright species, with patches of metallic gray, black, white, yellow, and fiery orange, while the Taiwan fulvetta is a typical duller

one, essentially pale gray-brown with pale orange in the wings. Many fulvettas are found in Southeast Asia. Ground babblers include more genera and species and are much more diverse, from warblerlike to jaylike birds, many of them rather like thrushes. There are groups such as wren-babblers, spotted thrush-babblers, scimitar-babblers, illadopsis, and grassbirds. Some are Asian, others African. They mostly have shortish, not particularly specialized bills, and short, strong legs, and have short wings. The black-capped babbler is a brown bird with pale orange and gray on the head and a neat black crown; illadopsis species are mostly dark warm brown and buff. Birds of this family occupy habitats from open, arid areas to swamps, many in more or less dense wet forest, and are essentially insectivorous.



PUFF-THROATED BABBLER
A bird more often heard than seen, the whistled chattering and loud calls of *Pellorneum ruficeps* are familiar jungle sounds. This bird is found from India to Southeast Asia and lives in brushwood and bamboo, from sea-level to 4,350 ft (1,300 m). The puff-throated babbler, 6½ in (16 cm) in length, is known to travel in small flocks.

Family Zosteropidae

White-eyes

Length 4–5½ in (10–14 cm)
Species 130



White-eyes are generally found around forest edges and canopy, from sea level up to 9,900 ft (3,000 m), in Africa and its islands, West Asia, South and Southeast Asia up to Japan, the Indian and Pacific oceans, and Australasia. They have slightly downward-curving, sharply pointed bills, brush-tipped tongues for feeding on nectar, and

small, rounded wings. Their most distinctive feature is a white ring around the eye, which varies in size and shape across the group and is the source of their name. Almost the entire family consists of pale green birds that resemble each other. They have a similar “peeuu” call, and the sexes are alike. Highly mobile birds, most white-eyes migrate away from cold weather. However, some nonmigratory populations are found on islands in the Indo-Pacific, where they are vulnerable to freak weather conditions. These birds form distinct subspecies, and they show a lack of genetic variation typical of animals that live in remote places.



JAPANESE WHITE-EYE
Widespread throughout South and Southeast Asia and introduced to Hawaii, *Zosterops japonicus*—about 4¼ in (10.5 cm) long—has a yellow throat and chin, and olive-green cap, back, and tail.



ORANGE RIVER WHITE-EYE
Common from forests to gardens in Botswana, Lesotho, Mozambique, Namibia, South Africa, and Swaziland, *Zosterops pallidus* is about 4¼ in (11 cm) long.

Family Irenidae

Fairy bluebirds

Length 10–12 in (25–30 cm)
Species 2



These tree-living birds are found in the evergreen or semideciduous forests of Asia: the blue-backed fairy bluebird in wetter parts of India, the Himalayas, southwest China, and Southeast Asia up to Borneo and Palawan in the Philippines; and the black-mantled fairy bluebird in the rest of the Philippines. They are noted for their very long upper and lower tail coverts, extending almost to the tip of the tail. Moving by day through the canopy in search of fruit, fairy bluebirds may also probe tree flowers for nectar. Several individuals may gather in a fig tree in fruit. They have a range of loud calls, including a sharp flight call. The blue-backed fairy bluebird nests in the forks of small trees, where the female builds a platform of twigs and incubates her 2 or 3 eggs. The male helps feed the young.

ASIAN FAIRY-BLUEBIRD
Despite the metallic-blue plumage, the male *Irena puella* can be inconspicuous in the canopy—but his repeated, sharp, double whistle often reveals his presence. Females are a duller blue. This bird is 10½ in (27 cm) long, and gathers to feed on fig trees, often with other species.



Family Certhiidae

Treecreepers

Length 4–6½ in (10–16.5 cm)
Species 11



Treecreepers are arboreal birds of North and Central America, Europe, Africa, and Asia, with thin, downcurved bills, brown plumage, and pale underparts. They use their stiffened tails for balance as they climb trees in search of insects in the bark, almost always climbing upward unlike nuthatches (see opposite). Their calls and song are high-pitched, and their nest, made of twigs, bark, and moss, is shaped like a loose hammock. They lay 2–9 eggs, which are incubated mostly by the female over 14–15 days. The young, which are fed by both parents, fledge in 14–16 days.

BROWN CREEPER
Once thought to be a subspecies of the treecreeper of Europe, *Certhia americana* breeds from Alaska to Newfoundland and south to Nicaragua, wintering in the south of its range. It is 5–5½ in (13–14 cm) long and climbs up trees in a spiral. It flies from the top of a tree to the base of another, searching for insects.

